

HIGH SCHOOLS

Cleveland Heights passes the Bedford test

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

If any Cleveland Heights fans are surprised by how tough Bedford played their team last night, they should talk to Tigers All-Ohio senior guard Damon Stringer.

"I'm not surprised at all," Stringer said after he helped Cleveland Heights turn away Bedford, 72-64, in a boys Division I district semifinal basketball game in Cleveland South High School.

"We play against them all summer; so I just knew they would come out strong and make it a tough game," Stringer said after he scored a game-high 29 points in front of his future coach, Ohio

State's Randy Ayers.

Cleveland Heights, the top-ranked team in the state by the Associated Press, will take a 21-1 record into Saturday's 1:30 p.m. district championship game at South. The Tigers will face Glenville (21-1) in a matchup of the No. 1 (Cleveland Heights) and No. 2 teams in the final Plain Dealer Top 25 poll.

"I think it's good to be tested any time you play," said Cleveland Heights coach Jim Cappelletti, who has guided the Tigers to 21 consecutive victories. "Like a lot of teams have done against us this season, they started out fast and really had the juices flowing."

Bedford (17-5), ranked fifth in

BOYS BASKETBALL

The Plain Dealer poll, jumped to an 8-2 lead and led, 17-9, after junior forward/guard Doc Taylor blocked a shot and converted the block into a dunk at the other end.

Cleveland Heights, which trailed, 21-15, after the first quarter, picked up its defensive pressure and tied the score on a follow by senior forward Keith Allen and a running one-hander and a breakaway layup by Stringer.

A jumper by Stringer off a turnover and a reverse layup by Allen off an offensive rebound put the Tigers in front, 25-21.

"We weren't intimidated at all," said Bedford coach Everett

Heard, who played on Cappelletti's first varsity team at Cleveland Heights (1970-71) and later became an assistant coach for the Tigers. "Our only concerns were how our three athletes, Taylor, [Sean] Thompson and [Shaunte] Miller, would match up against their key people, and whether or not our big men could hang with their big men, who are extremely quick."

The Bearcats dug tough as they cut the deficit to 27-26 on a 3-pointer by Taylor and moved to a 34-29 lead on a driving one-hander by Thompson and a jumper in traffic by Taylor.

Bedford, which lost to Cleveland Heights in the sectional finals two years ago, led, 47-40,

after senior forward Jevin Torain hit a 3-pointer with 2:25 left in the third quarter.

Cleveland Heights closed to 49-47 on a driving layup along the baseline by Allen, but Bedford, on the strength of a jumper by Taylor, held a 51-47 lead entering the final eight minutes.

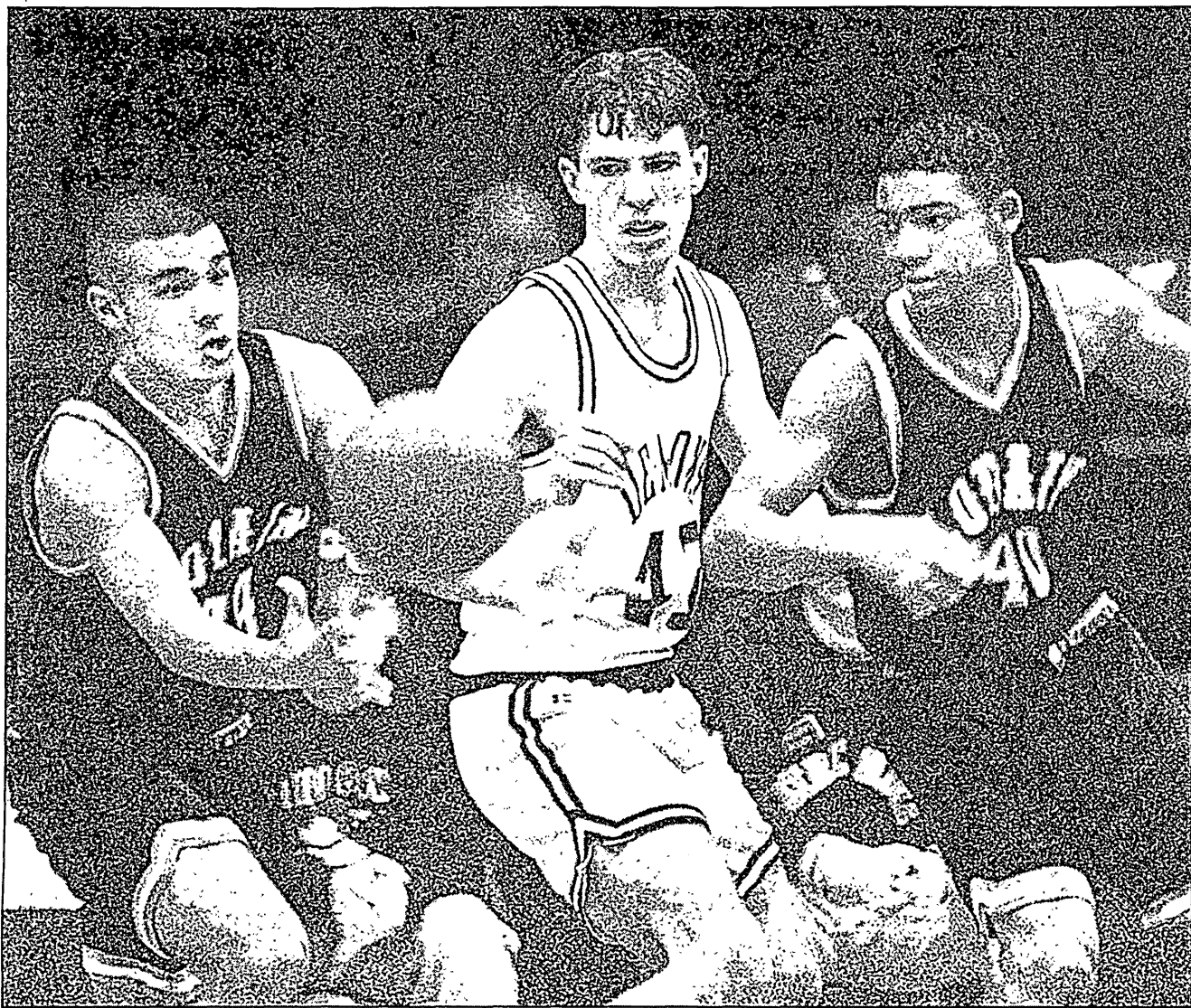
"I thought we really responded defensively, especially in the second and fourth quarters," said Cappelletti, who praised the rebounding efforts of Allen, senior forward Larry Moore and sophomore center Theo Dixon.

The Tigers responded after Bedford, behind another 3-pointer by Taylor and a layup by senior center Anthony Byrd, took a 61-57 lead with slightly more

than four minutes left. Taylor, the son of Glenville girls basketball coach Gretchen Taylor, finished with 23 points.

With the capacity crowd of more than 1,700 responding to every play, Cleveland Heights tied the score at 61 on two free throws by Dixon and a jumper by Stringer. The teams exchanged one-point leads until Allen pushed the Tigers' advantage to 67-64 on a layup off a Stringer assist with 1:29 left.

Hampered by a turnover, a missed basket from close range and a questionable charging foul on Thompson in the final 1:09, Bedford was turned away by the free-throw shooting of Moore and Dixon.



TONY DEJAK / ASSOCIATED PRESS PHOTOGRAPHER

Lorain's Joe Schwarz, left, and Londie Ransom go for the loose ball around Jon Myer of Westlake.

Lorain out-defenses Westlake

Steelmen will face Lakewood in district championship game

By JACK McDERMOTT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Lorain High turned in one of its better defensive efforts of the season last night, in a Division I district boys basketball semifinal at Midview.

"They totally outplayed us in every phase of the game, especially with their defense," Westlake coach Art Daniels said.

"We came into the game with a definite height advantage, but they attacked us on the boards, while offensively we just couldn't stop their guards. I've never seen a team with such a great desire to win."

Westlake closes the season at 18-4. Lorain takes its 16-6 record into the district championship game against top-seeded Lakewood on Saturday at 7 p.m.

"All the credit goes to my kids," said Lorain coach John Rositano. "They work hard in practice and they show up for every game ready to play. Winning is something they've got instilled in them, it's not something you can teach them."

BOYS BASKETBALL

After Lorain scored the first four points, on baskets by Carl White and Donald Church, the Demons tallied the next six to take their only lead of the game, 6-4.

Lorain closed out the first quarter with 3-point baskets by Joe Schwarz and Greg Williams.

The Steelmen pushed the advantage to 18-13 by the intermission, as Westlake connected on just 4 of 22 shots from the floor to the Steelmen's 6 of 15.

"We tried to regroup at the half and get the kids to pull together before we went back out for the third quarter," Daniels said. "We were playing too much as individuals and not at all as a team. For a brief time, at the onset of the third quarter, I thought things were going to turn around. Then we went right back to our old ways."

Westlake scored the first four points of the third quarter, with Todd Compton tossing in a 3-pointer, followed by a 3-footer from Jon Myer to make it 18-18 with 6:23 remaining.

The teams exchanged points before Lorain's Adam Lucas put the Steelmen on top to stay, 25-23, on a follow-up lay-in with 4:20 left in the third period. White tossed in a 3-pointer to push Lorain's advantage to 28-23 and the Steelmen were in charge.

Lorain's biggest lead came at 38-31 with 3:37 remaining in the game as White hit two free throws.

White had 14 points to lead Lorain. Williams scored 13.

The Demons were led by Myer with nine points. Zac Fiebig and Bret Fisher each scored eight.

"I was a little concerned when White picked up his fourth foul with a little more than three minutes left in the third quarter," Rositano said. "But Greg Williams stepped in and took charge."

"I'm beginning to sound like a broken record, but I can't emphasize enough how much credit goes to my kids for our success. I told them to just stay in their face on defense and then, when we had possession, to just control the basketball. They did all I asked of them."

Medina, Wadsworth conquer Summit

By TIM ROGERS
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Isn't this a hoot? Medina County 2, Summit County 0.

That's how the boys Division I district semifinals played out in University of Akron's James A. Rhodes Arena as Medina and Wadsworth from Medina County defeated Barborton and Akron Garfield from Summit County.

If Summit County was counting on its basketball-rich tradition to carry it last night it didn't work. Medina County might not be rich in basketball tradition but it is rich in district finalists today.

The two interlopers in the tournament dominated by Summit County teams will return to JAR on Saturday to determine next week's regional representative.

Medina wanted to control the tempo and it did. The Bees controlled the tempo so well they ran — or was it walked? — Barborton out of the tournament, 61-55.

Wadsworth made it all

BOYS BASKETBALL

Medina County district final when it eliminated Akron Garfield, 61-47, in the second game.

Led by the seniors who have carried them all season — Adrian Stockman, Carlos Tripp and Jeremy Krahe — Medina raised its record to 19-3 and advancing to within one game of making its first regional appearance since 1983.

Stockman, a 6-0 guard, scored 18 points and snuck behind the Barborton front line to pick off a game-high nine rebounds.

Tripp finished with 17 points and Krahe had 11 points and nine rebounds.

Junior Nate Vaughn led Barborton with 15 points and guard Terrance Parker and forward Latrell Jackson had 12 and 10 respectively.

"We thought we had a pretty good game plan and the kids followed it," Medina coach Keith

Sooy said. "We wanted to control the tempo and make sure that Barborton didn't go on any big spurts."

The Magics (12-11) weren't able to spurt after the first half. Sputter maybe, but no spurt.

"We've been playing pretty sharp lately," said Barborton coach Roger Cramer, whose team had knocked off Firestone and City Series champion Ellet to reach JAR. "Tonight we were just lethargic. As a coach you have no idea why that happens."

The first half was punctuated by scoring streaks by each team before ending with Medina on top, 28-24.

The Bees, winners of the school's first outright Pioneer Conference championship, went on a 14-2 run that was the bulk of a 16-9 advantage at the end of the quarter.

Barborton scored the first five points of the second quarter and took the lead at 19-18 on the first of three straight baskets by

Vaughn. The Magics extended the lead to 24-18 before Medina scored 10 straight to close the half. Four of those points came on Stockman's four-point play.

Each team scored 13 points in the third quarter. Medina had a 50-44 lead with 5:30 to play when it scored five straight points. The Bees were able to pad and protect their lead down the stretch by coming up with offensive rebounds after missing the first shot of five consecutive one-and-one free throws.

WADSWORTH 61, GARFIELD 47

Wadsworth led, 38-34, early in the second half when it scored seven straight points to eliminate the Rams (13-9).

Senior Chris Csatos scored 16 points and had 10 rebounds, and senior Charlie Parrish had seven points and nine rebounds as the Grizzlies (20-2) moved to the region one game of reaching the winners for the first time since 1981.

Garfield got 14 points and nine rebounds from Deon Bussey.

Olmsted Falls, Bay register victories

By DON FRIEDMAN
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Olmsted Falls is not finding its basketball tournament trail easy, but it is still alive after two overtime games.

The Bulldogs' latest adventure was a 62-60 double-overtime victory over Rocky River in a Division II district semifinal in Baldwin-Wallace's Ursprung Gym last night.

The win gives Falls a ticket to Saturday's 7 p.m. championship game against Bay (13-9). The Rockets defeated Elyria West, 62-47, in the second game.

The victory was particularly sweet for Falls because it was the second game the Bulldogs have played and won without 6-1 junior Tim Matus, the player coach Pat Donahue calls, "the glue of the team."

Matus was the quarterback on the football team and broke a leg with five minutes left in the last regular-season game.

Donahue figures his team has lost a lot without Matus' 11 points and 7½ assists a game.

Matt Tabar, a 6-0 junior, and Tim Schaefer, a 6-7, 240-pound sophomore, stepped up. Tabar, who averages 16 points, scored 27 last night, 20 of them in the second half, and Schaefer, who averages 17, scored 20 points and grabbed 16 rebounds.

"Both are on the All-Southwestern Conference team," Donahue said. "Without those two we wouldn't be here."

Falls led, 14-9, at the end of the first quarter. Schaefer scored six of the points.

The Bulldogs built a 23-13 lead with 3:40 left in the first half, but Rocky River came back with eight of the 10 points in the last 46 seconds to trail, 25-21. The eight came on a basket from Ryan Crane and 3-pointers from Chris Oatey and J.P. Moran.

BOYS BASKETBALL

Olmsted Falls never trailed in the third quarter, but again saw a seven-point lead cut to one on late baskets by Mike Lichko, Chad Standing and two of three free throws by Moran.

Rocky River tied the score at 36 with 7:19 left. The game was tied at 48 at the end of regulation.

Rocky River took a 51-47 lead with 2:05 to play in the first overtime. The Bulldogs pulled even on two free throws by 6-7 senior Nick Neumeister with three seconds left.

Falls took command in the second overtime with Schaefer taking a pass form Tabar and adding a free throw with 1:37 left. Standing cut the lead to one with a score off a rebound.

Neumeister made one of two foul shots, Schaefer made two free throws and Moore made one of two for a 60-55 lead.

Sean Kennedy gave Rocky River a basket with 17 seconds to go and Chris DeLisio had two foul shots. Falls led, 62-57, with 15 seconds to play. Kennedy swished a 3-pointer for Rocky River at the buzzer.

"I thought we played smart, but they killed us on the boards," said Rocky River coach Jim Rucki.

"We had chances at the end of regulation time and the first overtime."

Rocky River closed the season at 9-14.

The game started 45 minutes late because one of the officials thought he had the 8 p.m. game instead of the 6:30 start.

BAY 62, ELYRIA WEST 47

Michael Masterson and Frank Garrity led the Rockets with 14 and 13 points respectively. Nate Crutcher was high for Elyria West with 24 points.